

CAMBRIDGE UPSKILL

The Readiness Workshop

All about the Test

The Practice Test

LEVELS A1 — B1 · CEFR

A guide to your Upskill journey.

Read this booklet alongside your workshop session.

This booklet is your take-home companion for the workshop on **Upskill from Cambridge**. It explains what the test is, how each section works, and the practical strategies that will help you walk in confident on test day.

Keep it next to you during the workshop, and revisit it as you prepare. Each chapter mirrors a part of the session, so you can pause, take notes, and refer back to it whenever you need to.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOKLET

- **During the session:** follow along chapter by chapter.
- **Before the test:** revisit each section to refresh your strategy.
- **Take notes:** use the Notes pages at the back.

1. About Upskill from Cambridge

Upskill from Cambridge is a short, mobile-first English test designed by Cambridge English to measure your everyday language skills at the lower levels of the **Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR)**. It tests the four core skills — **Speaking, Listening, Reading, and Writing** — in just under 92 minutes of testing time.

Unlike longer, more academic exams, Upskill focuses on the practical English you actually use at work and in daily life: emails, conversations with colleagues, short notices, and voice messages.

Who is Upskill for?

Upskill is designed for adult learners who want to **certify their existing English ability** at the A1, A2, or B1 level. It is especially useful for:

- Job seekers who want a recognised proof of their English level for their CV.
- Professionals upskilling for a new role or promotion.
- Students preparing for further English study at higher CEFR levels.
- Anyone who needs a clear, official benchmark of their current level.

What does CEFR A1-B1 mean?

The CEFR is the international standard for describing language ability. Upskill assesses three levels:

Level	What it means in practice
A1 — Beginner	You can introduce yourself, ask and answer simple questions about familiar topics, and understand very basic phrases.
A2 — Elementary	You can communicate in simple, routine tasks. You can describe your background, immediate environment, and matters of immediate need.
B1 — Intermediate	You can deal with most situations while travelling, describe experiences, give reasons and opinions, and produce simple connected text on familiar topics.

Good to know. Upskill is *adaptive* within the A1–B1 range. The questions adjust as you work through the test, so the level you receive at the end reflects your actual performance, not a fixed pass mark.

Registering for the test

Upskill is taken on a mobile app. To register, you will need:

- A smartphone with a stable internet connection.
- **Wired headphones with a working microphone** for clear audio in the Listening and Speaking sections.
- A valid mobile number (the app uses it to send your authentication code).
- A quiet space where you can speak out loud without being interrupted.

Your workshop includes a **"Watch and Learn"** video that walks you through the registration step by step. Refer to it any time you get stuck.

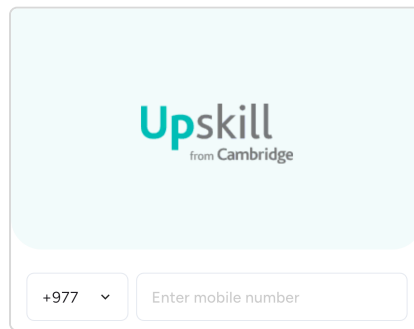


Figure 1.1 — The Upskill app login screen. Country code defaults to +977 in Nepal.

2. The Test Format

The test has **four sections**, taken in a fixed order on the Upskill app: Speaking, Listening, Reading, and Writing. You can complete each section in one sitting or spread them out, but once you start a section, you must finish it.

Section	Parts	Total time
Speaking	5 parts	12 minutes
Listening	5 parts	25 minutes
Reading	5 parts	25 minutes
Writing	2 parts	30 minutes

Total testing time: approximately 92 minutes.

What the dashboard looks like

When you log in, you will see a dashboard showing each of the four sections. As you complete one, it is marked with a green tick. You can begin the next section at any time.

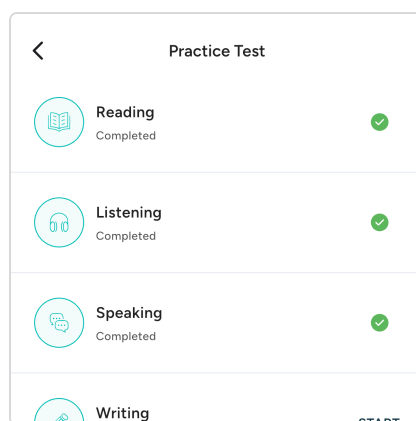


Figure 2.1 — The practice test dashboard. Completed sections show a green tick.

Three rules for every section

Whatever the skill, the same three habits will help you on every part of the test.

THE THREE TEST RULES

1. **Answer the easy questions first.** Don't get stuck on a hard one — skip it and come back if the section allows.
2. **Go back to the ones you skipped.** Use any time at the end to revisit anything you weren't sure about.
3. **Always check your answers before submitting.** A quick re-read often catches a small mistake that costs marks.

Before you start any section

Each section opens with a short instruction screen. Read it carefully — even if you have seen it before. The screen will tell you:

- How long the section lasts.
- How many parts it contains.
- That you are now in **secure test conditions** — you cannot leave or pause the section once it begins.

3. The Speaking Section

Speaking is the first section of the test. You will speak into your phone's microphone for a total of around 12 minutes, across 5 short parts. The app records your answers and assesses them automatically.

Before you begin, the app will ask permission to access your microphone. Always tap **Allow**.

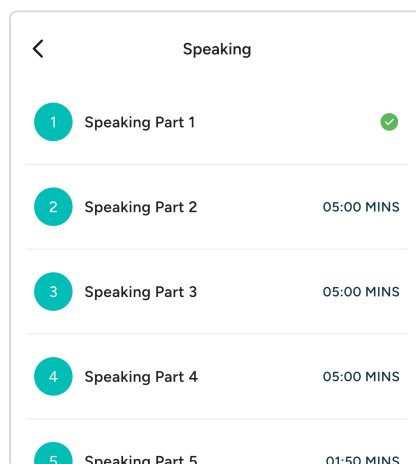


Figure 3.1 — The five parts of the Speaking section.

The five parts of Speaking

PART 1 Listen and answer

10 seconds per answer · 4 questions

You will hear 4 short questions and answer each one. Each question gives you 10 seconds to speak.

PART 2 Listen and answer (longer)

20 seconds per answer · 4 questions

Similar to Part 1, but you now have 20 seconds for each answer — enough time to give a fuller, more detailed response.

PART 3 Read aloud

10 seconds per sentence · 4 sentences

You will see 4 sentences on screen and read each one out loud. The app is checking your pronunciation and your handling of punctuation.

PART 4 Read aloud (extended)

10 seconds per sentence · 4 sentences

The same format as Part 3, with slightly more challenging sentences.

PART 5 Leave a message

40 seconds to prepare · at least 1 minute to speak

You read some short notes (an everyday situation), get 40 seconds to prepare, and then leave a voice message of at least one minute.

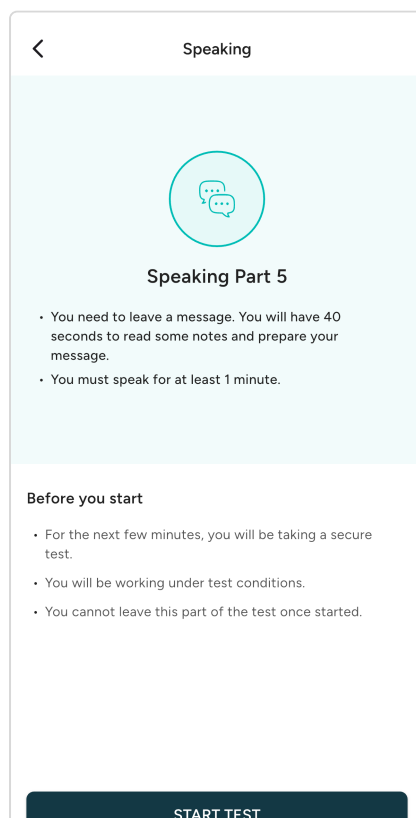


Figure 3.2 — Speaking Part 5: the longest and most open-ended task.

Strategies for the Speaking section

The Speaking section is graded by software, not a human examiner — so clarity and structure matter more than a polished accent. Focus on the basics: speak slowly, answer in full sentences, and use the question's own words in your reply.

HOW TO SCORE WELL

- **Do not rush.** Speaking slowly and clearly is much better than speaking quickly and making mistakes.
- **Answer in full sentences.** Never give a one-word answer. Always follow a statement with a reason or example.
- **Listen for the question word.** Be careful with *Where*, *When*, *Why*, *How* — they each ask for different information.
- **Use words from the question in your answer.** This makes your reply sound natural and focused.
- **If you make a mistake, correct it instantly.** Saying "*He go — he goes to the office*" is fine; pretending it didn't happen is worse.
- **Don't stop if you forget a word.** Use a filler ("*well*", "*you know*") or a simpler word, and keep going.

THE "BIG THREE" TENSES

Most Speaking answers need one of three tenses. Practising these three will cover the majority of test questions.

Tense	Use it for	Example
Present Simple	Habits, routines, facts	"I work in Tripureshwor every day."
Past Simple	Finished experiences	"Yesterday I visited my friend in Patan."
Future / Present Perfect	Plans, life events	"I will start a new job next month." / "I have lived here for five years."

FOR READ ALOUD (PARTS 3 AND 4)

- **Follow the punctuation.** Pause for a tiny second at a comma (,). Stop and breathe at a full stop (.).
- Read the sentence in your head once first if you have time.
- Don't worry about a perfect accent — aim for **clear, natural pronunciation**.

FOR PART 5 — THE LONG MESSAGE

- Use the **40 seconds of prep time** wisely. Plan a beginning, middle, and end.
- Aim to speak for the **full minute**, but do not repeat sentences just to fill time.
- Use linking words to connect ideas: *but*, *because*, *so*, *also*, *then*, *however*.
- Start with the keywords from the prompt — that immediately tells the marker you understood the task.

4. The Listening Section

Listening takes 25 minutes and has 5 parts. You will hear short recordings — usually workplace conversations, meetings, voicemails, or announcements — and answer questions based on what you hear.

You can tap a **Listen** button to play each recording. The number of replays allowed depends on the part, so always check the instructions before starting.

The five parts of Listening

PART 1 Chat with a colleague

You will hear short recordings as part of a chat. Choose the correct reply for each one. At the end, answer a comprehension question about the whole chat.

PART 2 Order the information

You will hear part of a meeting and see 5 pieces of information. Listen and put them in the correct order.

PART 3 Fill in the gap

You will hear four short recordings. For each one, you will see a sentence with a missing word. Listen and write the correct word in the gap.

PART 4 Choose the correct answer

You will hear four short recordings. For each, choose the correct answer from the options on screen.

PART 5 Choose the correct answer (extended)

Same format as Part 4, with longer recordings and slightly more challenging questions.

1/5

04:42

Listen and choose the correct reply

Listen

It's no problem.

Same as usual.

It's absolutely right.

SUBMIT

Figure 4.1 — A typical "choose the correct reply" item.

1/1

03:50

Put the actions the woman completed in the order you hear them.

Listen

Your answer:

Spoke to a possible new customer. X

Planned a business meeting. X

Wrote down which customers needed to pay. X

Contacted customers who needed to pay. X

Emailed her colleague some important information. X

SUBMIT

Figure 4.2 — An ordering task from Part 2.

Strategies for the Listening section

THE MOST IMPORTANT HABIT

Read the questions first. Then listen to the recording. Knowing what to listen for is the single biggest advantage you can give yourself. If the question asks "What time...?", you know to listen for a time. If it asks "Where...?", listen for a place.

WHILE YOU LISTEN

- **Don't panic if you miss a word.** Focus on the next sentence — the answer is usually there.
- **Listen for key information**, not every single word. Names, numbers, places, times, and reasons are often the answers.
- **Watch for words that change meaning** — *but, however, actually, in fact*. These often signal the correct answer.
- **Use the replay** if it's available. A second listen often catches what you missed.

FOR THE GAP-FILL TASKS (PART 3)

- Check the words around the gap before you listen — they tell you what kind of word fits (a number, a name, a place).
- Write exactly what you hear. Don't paraphrase.
- Check your spelling before you submit.

5. The Reading Section

Reading takes 25 minutes and has 5 parts. You will read short texts — notices, signs, emails, announcements, short articles — and answer comprehension or gap-fill questions about each.

Each part shows a progress bar at the top (e.g. 1/4) and a countdown timer. Pace yourself: aim for around 5 minutes per part.

The five parts of Reading

PART 1 Short texts, choose the meaning

You will read 4 short texts. For each one, choose the answer that best matches the meaning.

PART 2 Complete the sentence

You will read 4 short sentences with a missing word. Choose the correct word from the options.

PART 3 Complete the sentence (extended)

Same format as Part 2, with slightly more challenging vocabulary and grammar.

PART 4 Complete the sentence (advanced)

Same format again. The sentences usually test more nuanced word choice or grammatical accuracy.

PART 5 Longer text, comprehension

A longer reading passage followed by questions that check your understanding of the whole text.

Figure 5.1 — A typical Reading Part 1 question. Note the progress bar and timer.

Strategies for the Reading section

HOW TO READ EFFICIENTLY

- **Read the instructions carefully and thoroughly.** A misread instruction wastes the whole question.
- **Look for capital letters and numbers** — names of people, places, days, months, prices. They are often the answers to "Who?", "Where?", "When?", or "How much?" questions.
- **Answer the easy ones first.** Don't get stuck on a hard question. Mark it, move on, come back.
- **Guess from context.** If you don't know a word, look at the words around it. You can usually work out the meaning without understanding every single word.
- **Eliminate wrong answers.** In multiple choice, cross off the ones you know are wrong — then choose between what's left.

PACING YOURSELF

You have 25 minutes for 5 parts. That's about **5 minutes per part**. If a part has 4 questions, that's just over a minute per question. Don't spend three minutes on a single tough one — move on.

6. The Writing Section

Writing takes 30 minutes and has 2 parts. Each part asks you to write a short text — usually an email or a short reply — that addresses several specific points. You must write at least **50 words** for each task.

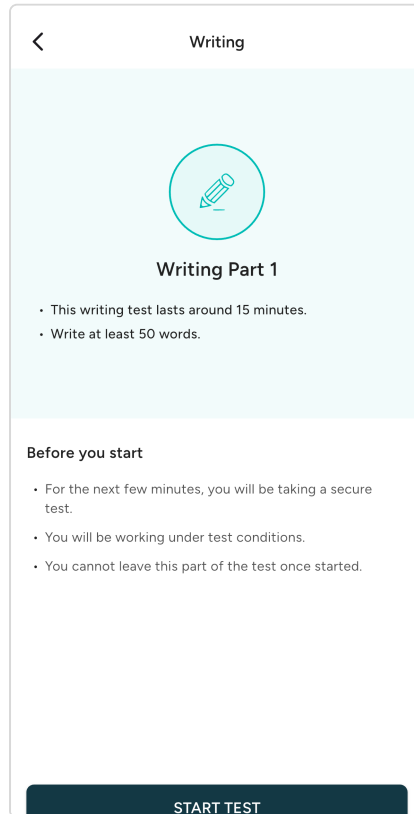


Figure 6.1 — The Writing Part 1 instructions screen.

The two parts of Writing

PART 1 Personal email

~15 minutes · at least 50 words

You write an email to a friend, family member, or colleague about an everyday situation — an invitation, a request, an update.

Example: "You want to invite your friend Mona to a football match this weekend. Write an email to Mona. In your email: invite Mona to the football match; tell Mona what time to arrive; suggest where to meet."

PART 2 Formal reply

~15 minutes · at least 50 words

You write a more formal text — for example, a reply to a job advertisement, a complaint, or a request to a business.

Example: "Reply to a job advertisement. Say why you are interested in applying for the position. Explain why you think you would be great at this job. Ask for an interview."

1/1

07:52

Reply to this ad to apply for the job:

Job ad

Re: Marketing Administrator

A telemarketing company is looking for a keen and capable Marketing Administrator. This customer-facing role requires great communication skills and the ability to create good customer relationships quickly. No previous experience is required, but you will need to show your communication skills in the first round of group interviews.

Reply to this ad to apply for the job:

You should

- say why you are interested in applying
- explain why you think you'd be great at this job
- ask for an interview.

Write at least 50 words. 64 WORD

respected hiring manager

I hope this email find you well. I am writing to express my interest in the position of Marketing Administrator in you company as advitised on company official website. While I

SUBMIT

Figure 6.2 — A live Writing Part 2 task. Note the running word counter at the bottom right.

Strategies for the Writing section

FIVE RULES THAT ALWAYS APPLY

- **Address every point.** Most prompts ask you to cover three things. Write at least one sentence for each.
- **Do not write less than 50 words.** The app counts as you type — keep an eye on it.
- **Keep your sentences simple.** A correct simple sentence beats a complicated sentence full of mistakes. *"I like pizza. It is very good. I eat it with my friends."*
- **Use basic linking words.** *and, but, because, also, first, second, then.*
- **Check spelling and grammar** before you submit. A quick re-read is worth a minute of your time.

A RELIABLE STRUCTURE FOR ANY EMAIL

1. **Greeting** — "Hi Mona," / "Dear Hiring Manager,"
2. **Reason for writing** — one short sentence on why you're writing.
3. **The three required points** — one or two sentences each.
4. **Closing line** — "See you soon!" / "I look forward to hearing from you."
5. **Sign-off** — Your name.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- Forgetting the greeting or sign-off.
- Writing one long paragraph instead of grouping ideas.
- Repeating the same point twice to reach 50 words — markers can see this.
- Using very informal language (slang, emojis, abbreviations like *u, ur, gr8*) — even in a friendly email.

7. Test Day Checklist

A short, calm checklist for the day you take the test. Print this page, or photograph it on your phone, and run through it before you begin.

Before you begin

- Charge your phone to at least 80%.
- Connect to a reliable Wi-Fi network.
- Find a quiet room where you will not be interrupted.
- Test your microphone by recording a short voice note.
- Have a glass of water nearby.
- Close all other apps so nothing interrupts the test.

During the test — quick reminders by section

SPEAKING

- Allow microphone access.
- Speak slowly and clearly.
- Full sentences, not one-word answers.
- Self-correct if you make a mistake.
- Use linkers: *but, because, so*.

READING

- Read instructions carefully.
- Look for capital letters and numbers.
- Easy questions first.
- Guess unknown words from context.
- About 5 minutes per part.

LISTENING

- Read the question *first*.
- Listen for key words: names, times, places.
- Don't panic if you miss a word.
- Use the replay if allowed.

WRITING

- Address every bullet point.
- At least 50 words — watch the counter.
- Greeting and sign-off.
- Simple sentences, basic linkers.
- Re-read before you submit.

8. Practice at Your Level

Upskill assesses you across **A1, A2, and B1**. This chapter gives you a feel for what each level looks like in real test-style tasks. Start with the self-check below to find your most likely level, then work through the practice samples for that level — and the one above it.

Quick self-check

Read each statement and tick the ones that describe you. Your highest "yes" group is roughly your current level.

If you can...	Your level is around...
Introduce yourself, say where you live, and name everyday objects.	A1
Talk about your daily routine and past weekend in simple sentences.	A1 → A2
Describe your job, family, and home in short paragraphs without much hesitation.	A2
Give an opinion, explain a reason, and tell a short story with linking words.	A2 → B1
Handle most everyday work and travel situations and write short emails for both.	B1

How to use the practice below. Each level shows you what one Reading text, one Writing task, and a few Speaking questions look like at that level. Read your level first; if it feels easy, try the level above. Answers for the reading tasks are at the end of this chapter.

A1 — Beginner

Very short texts, simple present tense, everyday objects and people.

READING SAMPLE

Hi Anita,
My name is Suman. I am from Pokhara. I live in Kathmandu now. I work in a hotel. I am a receptionist. I start work at 8 o'clock. I finish at 5 o'clock. On Saturday, I do not work. I visit my family.
See you soon!
Suman

Choose the correct answer.

1. Where does Suman work?
a) in a school b) in a hotel c) at home
2. When does Suman start work?
a) at 5 o'clock b) on Saturday c) at 8 o'clock

WRITING SAMPLE

Prompt: Write a short email to a new friend. Say your name, your city, and your job. (At least 50 words.)

Model answer (A1, 53 words):

Hi Bina,
My name is Rajan. I am from Nepal. I live in Lalitpur. I am twenty-five years old. I work in a small shop. I sell mobile phones. I like my job. I have one brother and one sister. They live in Chitwan. I am happy to meet you.
Please write to me soon.
Rajan

SPEAKING PRACTICE QUESTIONS

- What is your name?
- Where are you from?
- What is your job?
- What do you do on Saturday?

Tip: answer in 1–2 short sentences. "My name is Maya. I am from Bhaktapur."

A2 — Elementary

Short paragraphs, past simple, plans with *going to*, basic connectors.

READING SAMPLE

Office notice

Next Friday, the office will close at 1 p.m. for our annual cleaning day. Please take your important documents home on Thursday evening. The kitchen will not be open on Friday, so bring your lunch or eat outside. We will reopen as usual on Monday at 9 a.m. Thank you for your help!

— Office Manager

Choose the correct answer.

1. Why will the office close early on Friday?
a) because of a holiday b) for cleaning c) because the manager is away
2. What should staff do on Thursday evening?
a) bring lunch b) take important documents home c) clean the kitchen

WRITING SAMPLE

Prompt: *Your friend wants to visit Kathmandu next month. Write an email. Tell your friend three things to see, what food to try, and where to stay. (At least 50 words.)*

Model answer (A2, 62 words):

Hi Sara,
I am very happy you are coming next month! In Kathmandu, you must see Pashupatinath Temple, Boudhanath Stupa, and Durbar Square. They are beautiful and old. Please try momos and dal bhat — they are delicious. For your stay, Thamel is a good area because it has many small hotels. Send me your flight time and I will meet you. See you soon!
Anjali

SPEAKING PRACTICE QUESTIONS

- What did you do last weekend?
- What is your favourite food, and why?
- Tell me about your hometown.
- What are your plans for next year?

Tip: use *because* to give a reason. "*I like momos because they are tasty and cheap.*"

B1 — Intermediate

Longer texts, opinions and reasons, present perfect, more linking words (*however, although, instead*).

READING SAMPLE

Working from home: good or bad?

Since the pandemic, many companies in Nepal have allowed employees to work from home at least one or two days a week. Most workers say they enjoy this arrangement because they save time and money on travel. Parents, in particular, find it easier to balance work and family life.

However, working from home is not perfect. Some employees feel lonely without their colleagues, and others struggle with poor internet at home. A recent survey showed that while 70% of workers want to keep some home-working days, almost half also miss the energy of the office. The best solution, many managers now agree, is a mix of both.

Choose the correct answer.

1. What is the writer's main point?
a) Working from home is always better. b) A mix of home and office is the best solution. c) Most workers prefer the office.
2. According to the survey, what do almost half of workers miss?
a) saving travel money b) good internet c) the energy of the office
3. Which group especially benefits from working from home?
a) managers b) parents c) new employees

WRITING SAMPLE

Prompt: You read an advert for a new English course at your local college. Write a reply. Ask about the course schedule, the cost, and whether you can get a certificate at the end. (At least 50 words.)

Model answer (B1, 78 words):

Dear Sir or Madam,

I saw your advertisement for the new English course and I am very interested in joining. However, I have a few questions before I apply. Could you please tell me when the classes take place, as I work full-time during weekdays? I would also like to know how much the course costs in total. Finally, will I receive a certificate when I complete the course? I look forward to your reply.

Kind regards,

Pratima Shrestha

SPEAKING PRACTICE QUESTIONS

- What are the advantages and disadvantages of living in a big city?
- Tell me about a time you learned something new. How did you feel?
- Do you think technology has made people's lives easier? Why or why not?

- If you could change one thing about your job or studies, what would it be?

Tip: aim for 3–4 sentences per answer. Use linkers like *on the other hand*, *in my opinion*, *for example* to build longer responses.

ANSWER KEY

A1 Reading: 1) b — in a hotel · 2) c — at 8 o'clock

A2 Reading: 1) b — for cleaning · 2) b — take important documents home

B1 Reading: 1) b — a mix is best · 2) c — the energy of the office · 3) b — parents

Keep Practising

The best preparation for Upskill is regular, low-stress practice. These free websites are recommended by Cambridge English and the British Council. Use them in short sessions of 15–20 minutes a day.

British Council — LearnEnglish (Adults)

learnenglish.britishcouncil.org/skills

Free reading, listening, writing and speaking activities for adults, clearly labelled **A1, A2, B1** at the top of each page. Best place to practise at your exact level.

Write & Improve with Cambridge

writeandimprove.com

Write a short text and get instant feedback at your CEFR level. Especially useful for the Writing section.

Cambridge English — Activities for Learners

www.cambridgeenglish.org/learning-english/activities-for-learners

Free interactive activities across all four skills, tagged by CEFR level.

BBC Learning English

www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish

Short videos, podcasts, and "English in a Minute" clips. Great for daily listening practice.

A simple weekly plan

If you have two to three weeks before your test, this routine covers all four skills without becoming overwhelming.

Day	Focus	Suggested activity (15–20 min)
Mon	Listening	One BBC Learning English short clip + notes.
Tue	Reading	British Council A2/B1 reading exercise.
Wed	Speaking	Record a 1-minute voice note answering a question about your day.
Thu	Writing	Write a short email on Write & Improve. Review the feedback.
Fri	Vocabulary	Learn 10 new workplace words. Use each in a sentence.
Sat	Mixed	One full Upskill practice section in the app.
Sun	Rest	Watch one English-language film or show. No notes — just enjoy.

My Notes

Use this space during the workshop or as you work through the practice test.

You've got this.

This booklet is your companion — but the real preparation is the practice you do, day by day, in the weeks before your test.

Stay calm. Read carefully. Speak slowly. Write simply. And remember: every minute you spend in English is a minute closer to where you want to be.

UPSKILL FROM CAMBRIDGE · A1 — B1